

How to become Pilot in India

Becoming a pilot in India is a structured path that usually starts after Class 12 with Physics and Mathematics, followed by DGCA medicals, flying school training, theory exams, flying hours, and finally a Commercial Pilot Licence (CPL). The exact route depends on whether you want to become an airline pilot, a private pilot, or enter through a cadet program.

Pilot career path

The most common route to an airline career in India is:

1. Complete 10+2 with Physics and Mathematics.
2. Clear DGCA medical requirements.
3. Join a DGCA-approved flying school.
4. Complete ground school and flying hours.
5. Pass DGCA theory exams.
6. Clear practical flying checks.
7. Obtain CPL.
8. Add type rating.
9. Apply to airlines.

Eligibility

For a Commercial Pilot Licence in India, the main educational requirement is Class 10+2 or equivalent with Physics and Mathematics. DGCA rules state the applicant must be at least 18 years old for CPL, and official cadet program pages also mention medical clearance as a required step.

If you did not study Physics and Maths in school, some programs allow you to complete them through NIOS or equivalent routes before training.

Medical requirements

Medical fitness is a critical part of pilot training. You typically begin with DGCA Class 2 medicals, and before CPL-level progression you need Class 1 medical clearance from a DGCA-approved examiner.

This includes vision, hearing, general health, and other aviation fitness checks.

Training route

After eligibility and medicals, you enroll in a DGCA-approved flying school. Training usually includes ground school, simulator work, solo flying, dual flying, and practical assessments.

A standard CPL path also requires completing the required flying hours, with one source describing 200 hours of flying as part of the Indian CPL route.

Exams to clear

You will usually need to clear DGCA theory papers such as:

- Air Regulations.
- Navigation.
- Meteorology.
- Technical subjects.
- RTR related requirements.

These exams are often studied alongside flight training rather than after it.

Types of pilot careers

There are several pilot paths in India:

- Student Pilot License route.
- Private Pilot route.
- Commercial Pilot route.
- Cadet pilot program.
- Military pilot route through defence entry.

For airline jobs, CPL plus type rating is the usual route. Cadet programs can offer a more direct airline-focused pathway, but they also have specific eligibility and selection requirements.

Costs and planning

Pilot training is expensive, so planning matters. Costs can include medicals, exam fees, ground school, flying hours, uniform, accommodation, and later type rating.

Before enrolling, compare:

- DGCA approval.
- Fleet availability.
- Flying hours offered.
- Aircraft type.
- Safety record.
- Placement support.

Type rating and airline entry

After CPL, many candidates take type rating on a commercial aircraft such as an Airbus A320 or Boeing 737 before applying to airlines. Air India and other programs highlight type rating and structured recruitment as part of the airline pathway.

This step is important because a CPL alone is not enough for most airline cockpit jobs.

Skills needed

A successful pilot needs more than flying ability. Important qualities include:

- Discipline.
- Situational awareness.
- Communication.
- Decision-making.
- Stress management.
- Technical understanding.
- Team coordination.

Strong English communication is especially important because aviation operations rely on precise communication.

What to do after 12th

If you are starting after 12th, a practical action plan is:

1. Check Physics and Math eligibility.
2. Book DGCA medicals.
3. Research approved flying schools.
4. Prepare for theory subjects.
5. Apply for training.
6. Complete flying hours.
7. Clear CPL requirements.
8. Do type rating.
9. Apply for airline or charter jobs.

Pilot roadmap summary

A simple version of the journey is:

Class 12 + Physics/Math → Medicals → Flying School → DGCA Exams → Flying Hours → CPL → Type Rating → Airline Job.